

The Forever War of Myanmar

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Introduction

Myanmar, also known as Burma, is the only country that has been in conflict every year since independence.¹ Yet, out of the seventy-six years in which Myanmar has enjoyed both its independence and has been in conflict, not a single one of those years included the event of an inter-state conflict. Rather, Myanmar has had a chronic case of internal conflicts and civil wars. The primary reason for the continuation of this conflict lies in the objectives of the various ethnic groups that make up Myanmar and account for around one-third of the population.² There are over 25 armed factions that operate within Myanmar with the most notable being the Kachin and the Wa.³ The objectives of the various ethnic groups were a plight for self-determination and autonomy from an increasingly prosecuting military government, called the Tatmadaw came to power after the 1964 coup.⁴ These persecutions can be seen through examples of ethnic genocide such as the Rohingya genocide where in 2016-17 the Tatmadaw went on a brutal campaign against the Rohingya, killing thousands of people and displacing many more.⁵ While there have been attempts at peace with both the Tatmadaw granting autonomy to some groups and attempting to build a democratic state, they have not lasted. The most recent example of this comes from the 2011 democratic reforms which the Tatmadaw implemented in hopes for it to lead to ceasefires between the government and the various ethnic groups.⁶ These ceasefires did eventually come with the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement which eight out of the fifteen major armed ethnic groups signed with multiple more joining in later years.⁷ The agreement collapsed

¹Alvaro Aguirre, "The Risk of Civil Conflicts as a Determinant of Political Institutions," *European Journal of Political Economy* 42 (March 2016): 36–59, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ejpolco.2016.01.002>. Pp 49.

²Lindsay Maizland, "Myanmar's Troubled History: Coups, Military Rule, and Ethnic Conflict," Council on Foreign Relations, January 31, 2022, <https://www.cfr.org/background/Myanmar-history-coup-military-rule-ethnic-conflict-rohingya>.

³Antonio Graceffo, "Backgrounder: Ethnic Armies in Myanmar Civil War," Geopolitical Monitor, August 12, 2024, <https://www.geopoliticalmonitor.com/backgrounder-ethnic-armies-in-the-myanmar-civil-war/>.

⁴Max Hoque Kazi et al., "The Civil War in Myanmar," February 6, 2023, <https://carleton.ca/cifp/wp-content/uploads/Myanmar-Conflict-Diagnostic-2023.pdf>.

⁵Lindsay Maizland, "Myanmar's Troubled History: Coups, Military Rule, and Ethnic Conflict," Council on Foreign Relations, January 31, 2022, <https://www.cfr.org/background/Myanmar-history-coup-military-rule-ethnic-conflict-rohingya>.

⁶Jiwon Lee, "Settlements in the Civil Wars of Myanmar and Sri Lanka: The Success, Failure and Deception of the Peace Process," *Sage Journals*, April 5, 2016, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0976399615624057>.

⁷Wai Moe and Thomas Fuller, "Myanmar and 8 Ethnic Groups Sign Cease-Fire, but Doubts Remain," *The New York Times*, October 15, 2015, <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/10/16/world/asia/myanmar-ceasefire-armed-ethnic-groups.html>.

after the 2021 coup, when the Tatmadaw, citing election fraud, established the State Administration Council (SAC) following a surprising loss to the National League for Democracy (NLD). This led to the ongoing civil conflict, with the Tatmadaw fighting armed ethnic groups and the NLD's remnant, the People's Defence Force (PDF). Myanmar's persistent civil unrest is a unique anomaly, as the country has never experienced lasting peace. The situation is fueled by the Tatmadaw's escalating conflict with rebels, a lack of trust, and inconsistent foreign support, particularly from China. True peace can only be achieved through the Tatmadaw's shift toward democracy, reconciliation, and stronger international intervention, especially from China.

A. An Escalating Commitment Problem

Peace isn't an improbability within Myanmar but rather isn't consistent around the entire country. This can be seen with the previous democratic transition and the ceasefires that followed. The former event was supposed to be a backdrop to bring up the Tatmadaw's reputation as simply the military force within Myanmar, while not losing its administrative influence by allowing itself to keep a minimum of twenty-five percent of the legislature.⁸ In exchange, they gave NLD "free elections, freedom of the press, and the formation of a civilian government".⁹ This exchange within itself is a solution to the commitment problem that the military has, or even framed as a solution towards a Thucydides trap situation. Within this deal, the Tatmadaw would traditionally be a steady or declining power while the democratic forces in Myanmar, NLD, would be the rising power as more people protest and strive for democracy. Thus, the Tatmadaw created a deal that caps its potential loss in a democratic transition to a point where it can still veto legislation that doesn't support its cause.

⁸Maung Aung Myoe, "9, Partnership in Politics: The Tatmadaw and the NLD in Myanmar since 2016," *Myanmar Transformed?*, December 31, 2018, 201–30, <https://doi.org/10.1355/9789814818551-013>.

⁹Heiduk, "Civil War in Myanmar," Stiftung Wissenschaft und Politik (SWP), accessed November 14, 2024, <https://www.swp-berlin.org/10.18449/2021C35>. Pp 2.

This approach of capping potential losses that could come from a failure of a commitment problem continues into the realm of ceasefires. This is done by allowing “the ethnic leaders were allowed to keep arms, territories, and administrations, and a ceasefire under these terms was considered a better alternative”.¹⁰ Thus, if the Tatmadaw backtracks on its agreement or starts attacking other ethnic groups, the ethnic groups that did sign would be able to see the writing on the wall and be able to act accordingly. To be frank, this is the bargaining model at work as both sides don’t want to be held to a commitment problem but also don’t want to continue the loss that would occur through conflict. After the gradual transition towards democracy, the Tatmadaw convened the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement under this strategy which led to eight out of the fifteen combating ethnic groups signing into a ceasefire. While none of the major armed ethnic groups, such as the Kachin and the Wa, there was hope that eventually, that would change as two more groups eventually did sign in the coming years.^{11 12} Thus, given time there was a possibility that the remainder of the group.

However, as time came the only thing to arrive was the fact that the Tatmadaw had broken the commitment. This started in 2016 with the Rohingya genocide, which was aided by the fact that Aung San Suu Kyi, the State Counsellor of Myanmar at that time, stated “The Rohingya are foreigners who have no place in Myanmar”.¹³ This just stoked the fears of the other ethnic minorities as it had seemed that the Byrma majority government would not only not defend their fellow citizens, even though Myanmar formally protects all of its 135 minorities, but would also encourage their destruction and displacement.¹⁴ This simply made it so that

¹⁰ Jiwon Lee, “Settlements in the Civil Wars of Myanmar and Sri Lanka: The Success, Failure and Deception of the Peace Process,” *Sage Journals*, April 5, 2016, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0976399615624057>.

¹¹ Wai Moe and Thomas Fuller, “Myanmar and 8 Ethnic Groups Sign Cease-Fire, but Doubts Remain,” *The New York Times*, October 15, 2015, <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/10/16/world/asia/myanmar-ceasefire-armed-ethnic-groups.html>.

¹² “2 Groups Join Myanmar Government’s Peace Process,” *AP News*, February 13, 2018, <https://apnews.com/general-news-e668736f3c4b44cfa310addefd4da1e3>.

¹³ Armand Sadovschi, “Post-Colonial Identity and Power Politics. the Case of Myanmar’s Civil War,” *EIRP Proceedings*, July 31, 2024, <https://dp.univ-danubius.ro/index.php/EIRP/article/view/490>. Pp 7.

¹⁴ Armand Sadovschi, “Post-Colonial Identity and Power Politics. the Case of Myanmar’s Civil War,” *EIRP Proceedings*, July 31, 2024, <https://dp.univ-danubius.ro/index.php/EIRP/article/view/490>. Pp 3.

Rohingya's case was seen as the canary in the mine causing "ethnic minorities to now temporarily unite only by their common resentments towards the majoritarian Bamarese and the military junta".¹⁵ It cannot be understated how much this sets back the possibility of peace as any of the potential reputation that the Tatmadaw and the unified government would have had in being a just authority would have been squandered. Thus, creating even greater distrust and holding back all ethnic groups from committing to a national ceasefire. To the point that the Myanmar government would eventually start labeling groups such as the Myanmar National Democratic Alliance Army (MNDAA), Ta'ang National Liberation Army (TNLA), and Arakan Army as terrorist organizations.¹⁶

As for the Government, that union would also fall apart from the 2021 coup. This led to not only ethnic groups being distrustful of the government but also the democratic forces in that government actively rebelling and becoming distrustful of any future attempts at democratization from the Tatmadaw. Overall, the rightful distrust that is felt by the various ethnic groups about the Tatmadaw makes the chance that both sides commit to a long-term peace slim to none.

B. International Influences, Or Lack Thereof

There is a variety of international actors which interact with Myanmar and the land it inhabits. This includes the United States, India, terrorist organizations, and China. However, within the confines of this civil war, these actors interaction is limited and their influence is even more so. Starting with the United States, its main intervention in the conflict is through economic means by levying sanctions on the Tatmadaw-led government due to their atrocities.¹⁷ This is the approach that the majority of the Western world took when addressing the onset of the most

¹⁵ Armand Sadovschi, "Post-Colonial Identity and Power Politics. the Case of Myanmar's Civil War," EIRP Proceedings, July 31, 2024, <https://dp.univ-danubius.ro/index.php/EIRP/article/view/490>. Pp 7.

¹⁶ Al Jazeera, "Myanmar Regime Labels Key Ethnic Armed Groups 'terrorist' Organisations," Al Jazeera, September 5, 2024, <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2024/9/4/myanmar-regime-labels-key-ethnic-armed-groups-terrorist-organisations>.

¹⁷ Celia Hatton, "Myanmar: Firms across 13 Countries Supporting Military with Training & Weaponry Materials, UN Officials Find," Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, January 16, 2023, <https://www.business-humanrights.org/en/latest-news/myanmar-firms-across-13-countries-supporting-military-with-training-and-weaponry-materials-un-officials-find/>.

recent events of the conflict, especially the genocide and reversal of democratic practices. This practice, while effective at damping and power of the Tatmadaw, does little in terms of the conflict on the ground. As for India, their relationship is just as non-contact as the United States with the primary mode of discussion which is made by Myanmar detaining and extraditing terrorists and militants that have been attacking India but harboring in Myanmar.¹⁸ From an initial point of view, this would seem like Myanmar would be a state where passive support is allowed to international terrorist groups due to the weakness prevented from the state due to the prolonged civil war. However, this is not the case. In a statement from Ambassador Hau Do Suan, Permanent Representative of Myanmar to the United Nations, he states “Recently, some FTFs had tried to enter Myanmar territory from one of our neighboring countries in Southeast Asia in an attempt to reinforce ARSA terrorist activities”.¹⁹ While this would symbolize the presence of an international terrorist organization and the potential for future passive support depending on the changes in the power of the Tatmadaw. It also means that for the last couple of decades, the military government has been successful, for the most part, in localizing this conflict strictly inside Myanmar. The only other exception to that is with its relationship with China.

Chinese involvement in the conflict has been the longest-standing, through different methods and on different sides of the civil conflict. China has supported the Tatmadaw through both resources such as copper but also through international protection by vetoing any harmful resolutions within the United Nations Security Council.^{20 21} They also supply physical investment

¹⁸Ne Now News, “Myanmar Army Hands over 22 ‘most Wanted Militants’ from Northeast India, Including Top UNLF and NDFB Commanders,” NorthEast Now, November 11, 2021, <https://nenow.in/top-news/myanmar-army-hands-over-22-most-wanted-militants-from-northeast-india-including-top-unlf-and-ndfb-commanders.html>.

¹⁹Hau Suan, “Myanmar Statement -- International Terrorism,” Statement by Ambassador Hau Do Suan, Permanent Representative of Myanmar to the United Nations on Agenda Item 109“Measure to Eliminate International Terrorism” at the Sixth Committee of the 74rd Session of the United Nations General Assembly, accessed November 15, 2024, https://www.un.org/en/ga/sixth/74/pdfs/statements/int_terrorism/myanmar.pdf.

²⁰Celia Hatton, “Myanmar: Firms across 13 Countries Supporting Military with Training & Weaponry Materials, UN Officials Find,” Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, January 16, 2023, <https://www.business-humanrights.org/en/latest-news/myanmar-firms-across-13-countries-supporting-military-with-training-and-weaponry-materials-un-officials-find/>.

²¹United Nations, “Security Council Fails to Adopt Draft Resolution on Myanmar, Owing to Negative Votes by China, Russian Federation | Meetings Coverage and Press Releases,” United Nations, 2007, <https://press.un.org/en/2007/sc8939.doc.htm>.

by building the “Kyaukphyu deep-sea port and the proposed Myitsone Dam project”.²² However, Chinese actions within Burma aren’t always to the benefit of the national government. This can be seen with its economic ties and support of the Wa State and the communist faction that previously occupied it. China would buy rare earth materials from them and even safe-harbored Communist leaders when they were exiled from Myanmar in a form of passive support.²³ Another example of waning Chinese aid is after the democratic reforms where investments from China decreased or were even cut entirely. The most notable example of this came with the Myitsone Dam which was stopped after continual disagreement between the new democratic regime and China.²⁴ Altogether, the Myanmar civil war has a slew of international actors that have the potential to change the conflict but the reality is that other than China none of them have the will nor intention to do so. Thus, the war will continue to be localized within the border of Myanmar.

C. Catch-22: The Proposal Of Peace

Given the fact that the conflict has lasted over seventy-six years with no resolution, it is good to say that peace is a less than probable outcome within the near future. Yet, it is not impossible. To get to this peace the following conditions must be met: Further Chinese involvement as a third party, further commitments to democratization, and the continuation of Myanmar policy in terms of letting ethnic groups keep their militias.

The most critical of these three factors is the involvement of China. While in the public view, interventions in civil wars just make them more messy, there are conditions for which interventions can promote peace. Barbara F. Walter, a political scientist with a focus on civil

²²Joaquin Matamis, “China in Myanmar: How the Game-Changing Neighbor Would Continue to Maintain Its Influence • Stimson Center,” Stimson Center, September 11, 2024, <https://www.stimson.org/2024/china-in-myanmar-how-the-game-changing-neighbor-would-continue-to-maintain-its-influence/>.

²³Magnus Fiskej , “The Wa of Myanmar and China’s Quest for Global Dominance,” *The Journal of Asian Studies* 82, no. 4 (August 16, 2023): 759–61, <https://doi.org/10.1215/00219118-10773671>. Pp 1.

²⁴Yun Sun, “China and the Changing Myanmar,” *Journal of Current Southeast Asian Affairs* 31, no. 4 (December 2012): 51–77, <https://doi.org/10.1177/186810341203100403>.

wars, states “Civil wars almost always chose to fight to the finish unless an outside power stepped in to guarantee a peace agreement...If a third party did not intervene, these talks usually failed”.²⁵ Walter further goes on to note that between 1940 to 1990 belligerents within civil wars were almost always unable to reach a negotiated peace without the guarantee of an outside force.²⁶ This is primarily because both sides aren’t able to sustain the commitment to peace without the threat of potentially being betrayed, such as the many times the Tatmadaw has betrayed the various ethnic groups and democratic forces in Myanmar. Thus, China, the only outside power interested in the conflict, must act as the enforcer of peace to counter-act the commitment problem at hand.

Secondly, the Tatmadaw must make a genuine commitment to building a functional democracy, allowing rebel groups to express their grievances through political, rather than military, means. This is one of the toughest challenges in the conflict, as it would require the Tatmadaw to relinquish or significantly weaken its control, as seen when its political party was limited to just 25% of the legislature. Furthermore, this would likely strain relations with China, given that the previous democratic government sought to distance itself from China in favor of closer ties with the United States. Thus, granting Myanmar’s minorities access to political power represents the most difficult obstacle to achieving peace.

The final proposal is the continuation of the Tatmadaw policy to allow rebel groups to keep their arms as a means to counteract the commitment problem. This is a requirement that is extremely abnormal within most civil war settlements but has been prevalent in cease-fires within Myanmar.²⁷ This allows the rebel groups to have a backdoor if the Tatmadaw deflects

²⁵Barbara F. Walter, “The Critical Barrier to Civil War Settlement,” *International Organization* 51, no. 3 (1997): 335–64, <https://doi.org/10.1162/002081897550384>. Pp. 335.

²⁶Barbara F. Walter, “The Critical Barrier to Civil War Settlement,” *International Organization* 51, no. 3 (1997): 335–64, <https://doi.org/10.1162/002081897550384>. Pp. 360.

²⁷Barbara F. Walter, “Bargaining Failures and Civil War,” *Annual Review of Political Science* 12, no. 1 (June 1, 2009): 243–61, <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.polisci.10.101405.135301>. Pp 246.

from its promises of peace or starts to initiate ethnic violence such as in the case seen with the Rohingya genocide. Additionally, it forced the Tatmadaw to calculate its options before committing to an offensive which would most likely be solved through the bargaining model within politics. As Clausewitz famously stated, “War is nothing but a continuation of politics by other means.”²⁸ By both allowing greater access to politics for the rebels and by leveraging the bargaining model to force the Tatmadaw to seek a political solution there is a way to seek peace within the forever war of Myanmar.

Conclusion

The conflict in Myanmar has lasted far beyond a single lifetime, with multiple attempts at peace ending in failure, the most significant being the 2021 coup d'état. The long duration of the conflict, combined with numerous betrayals during peace negotiations, has made the commitment problem between the two sides more entrenched than ever. The conflict is largely self-sustaining, with few outside actors directly or continuously involved, the main exception being China. As such, lasting peace in Myanmar seems highly improbable. With active attempts at peace, being dismissed by the side of the rebels.²⁹ However, "improbable" does not mean "impossible." There are certain conditions both sides could pursue to mitigate or even resolve the commitment problem: increased international involvement from China, the creation of a more equal political arena for both sides to resolve their differences, and the continuation of the Tatmadaw's policy of allowing rebel groups to retain their arms as a safeguard if the settlement fails. While these conditions are difficult to pursue and may conflict with the desires of the parties involved, they represent the cost of achieving peace and ending a forever war.

²⁸Carl Clausewitz, “On War Quotes by Carl von Clausewitz,” Goodreads, accessed November 21, 2024, <https://www.goodreads.com/work/quotes/2048326-on-war>.

²⁹Kelly Ng, “Myanmar Rebels Reject Embattled Junta’s Peace Offer,” BBC News, September 27, 2024, <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cj04955442ro>.

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